GERMAN PANZER CREWS

The mastermind behind Nazi Germany's panzer divisions was General Heinz Guderian. In the 1930s he evolved the tactical approach that would become known as "blitzkrieg". He envisaged massed tank formations, supported by motorized infantry and artillery, punching through weak points in the enemy defences and pressing on at speed to exploit the opening in depth. "If the tanks succeed," General Guderian wrote in 1937, "victory follows". Unlike many proponents of armoured warfare Guderian won government backing for his plans – Hitler was an enthusiastic believer in the shock effect of maximum force.

BLITZKRIEG AND ATTRITION

In the early years of World War II Germany had fewer armoured vehicles than its enemies, and the tanks that it did have were not technologically superior. Germany's tank commanders and crews, however, were unequalled in their skill and initiative. Scything across northern France in the summer of 1940, Guderian's panzers initially produced the lightning victory he had predicted. After Rommel took command of the Afrika Korps in January 1941, he repeatedly outmanoeuvred and outfought the British tanks in the desert war. It was the same story in the Soviet Union in 1941–42. Gradually, however, the panzers were overwhelmed on all fronts by the sheer weight of numbers opposing them.

In the later years of the war, the Germans introduced the Tiger and Panther tanks, machines matched only by the Soviet T-34 for the power of their guns and the protection afforded by their armour. In the slogging battles fought in Normandy in July 1944, where speed and manoeuvrability were negated by hedges and banks, they took a terrible toll on Allied tanks. One Panther is credited with destroying nine Shermans in a day. But on the Eastern Front these sophisticated machines, supplied in too small numbers and with an alarming tendency to break down, had no chance of reversing the tide of defeat. Unlike the Luftwaffe, the German panzers never suffered a degradation in the quality of personnel. Fighting without air cover and short of fuel, they often outfought their opponents to the bitter end.

Panzer driver's uniform
Panzer crewmen wore short, close-fitting jackets suitable for the cramped conditions inside a tank. Panzer crews who were members of the Waffen SS (the combat arm of the SS) carried SS victory runes on their uniforms as well as rank and divisional markings.



"THE ENGINE OF THE PANZER IS A WEAPON JUST AS THE MAIN GUN."

GENERAL HEINZ GUDERIAN